

Mike Dirksens' life as dictated to his wife Eileen
January 27, 1994

I was born in Kulm, N. Dakota, June 30, 1921, to Abraham and Christina Dirksen. At about 2 years of age we moved to Mankato, Minnesota. I went to first grade in Mrs. Searles class. It was a little country school. Four of us in first grade, Merton Searle in 8th grade and two girls in between. The next year we moved to St. Paul. My father was a minister all the time after I was born.

From St. Paul, 2nd and 3rd, 4th and 5th grade in Minneapolis, across the river. We rode on street cars to school. And also my bicycle, we had a lot of snow. I walked through the snow to school or on the street car.

We moved to western Kansas and I started 6th grade when I was 12. I liked Kansas. My father was minister of Bison, Nekomis, and the biggest church and school in Shafer and Bazine. We had a home in LaCrosse. I liked the public school there and played football and baseball. I went to the LaCrosse school K-12, elementary and high school were on one plot of ground. Vera moved there with us when we did. She had finished her nurses training in Boulder, CO and was taking care of mother, she was ill. She was 50 years old and had had all her teeth pulled. It was very traumatic for her.

I went to E.A. when I was 14. I made up a year with correspondence school and I was a sophomore. I liked Enterprise Academy where I attended 3 years. When I was a junior I painted and wallpapered for two weeks after school was out, to help on the tuition etc. I went home to Topeka, KS one year and worked for a man putting down cement floors in bathrooms of a hotel in Manhattan, KS. Bought my first car. My dad bought it from a Church member, a car salesman (Jack and Mary Bogle). He liked dad and went on to be a book salesman and a minister. We see him out here once in awhile.

The next year 1940, (August) Eileen and I were married in the Wichita, Kansas church. Then we drove to Minneapolis and lived upstairs in one of dad's old houses. After Michael was born in Waysata Lake, a resort town outside of Minneapolis, we moved to ElDorado, KS.

I drove a truck with my father in law for 6 months. Then we moved to West Hollywood, CA. I had a job at the Schrillo Aero Tool Co. (a small place) in west Hollywood.

After 1 year I was called to report for the Army in Los Angeles. Then I had to report to Junction City, KS. We moved to ElDorado. Steven J. was born in ElDorado.

He was 4 months old when we moved to Lincoln, NE in a two story house. Kathy was born there when Steve was 2 years 3 months old. After she was 4 years old we moved to Wichita.

I attended Friends Univ. when I was 30 years old. I was busy all the time. Working: Interior decorating on my own, and working odd hours. I graduated when I was 36 years old. We moved to Loma Linda, Michael was 15, Steve 12 and Kathy 10. They attended and graduated from Loma Linda Academy. I started teaching in Lucerne Valley for a year and a half. Feb. 1958, I was 36 ½. I went to Victoria School, Sept 59' Redlands School Dist. First, Special Ed kids, then I went to a regular classroom. Lugonia 1 year, then Cope Jr. High and then Cram half a year. Went to district office and went to work for Bill Gibson, as business manager 8 ½ years. Keeping the budget balanced. During

that time I joined CASBO, A.C.S.A. and was active in teachers Assoc. R.T.A. during my teaching years. After that I became friends with Al Smith, Supt. Of Chaffey High School Dist. We met in the A.C.S.A. meetings. Then I was hired as business manager for 1 year in Chaffey Dist. Then I became Superintendent for 12 years. I retired in 1988.

We had lived in Redlands during all these years. I worked as interim Supt of Chino from 1988-89. I had a heart attack on New Years day 1990.

The first 6-8 weeks I recovered, regaining some of my strength, then felt good. I had never been sick before. I had a low pain tolerance and was feeling good again. From 1990 Jan. to June 1992 didn't work in school district – with Cunningham – just went to conferences and luncheons to meet Superintendent – re: building schools and acquiring our loans. Still consulting for Chaffey schools, about ½ day a week.

June 1992 – Feb 93, Interim Supt in Cucamonga. Feeling great, super good all the time. Feb. flew to Disney world stayed in a Peabody hotel, staying there for 5 nights. Had bad connections re: time because of snow in Denver. Came home, started getting ready to “retire”. Built small shed in June and July. Went to Dr. Gary Marias, June 1 (after we'd been in Fairfield, CA.) I went to Dr. Marias for a month. There were several excuses, unmentionable. Which put off starting the Capoten (sp?)

The way my life turns out is just fate. I'm very satisfied. Life was great. I fulfilled all my accomplishments to my highest satisfaction. Many of which weren't even planned.

Mike Dirksen 1-27-94

As narrated to his wife Eileen.

Typed by Steve 8-14-03

From the original handwritten document from mom

Mike and I were married when we were 19 years old, after one year of college. We always loved and respected each other. We had lived 2 years in Minnesota after Michael was born. And Kansas and California 3 years, then settled in Lincoln, Nebraska a while. After Steve was 6 months Mike attended college a while but stopped. Kathy was born And there was much work to be done. I went to work in a fine, big rest home near our house and was studying a nursing course by correspondence. My year of pre nursing subjects at Union College helped me too. I worked nights, 11 PM to 7 AM as charge nurse over 20 patients.

When we moved to Wichita to live, Kathy was 4, Steve 6 years and Michael was 9. They went to S.D.A. church school. Mike held offices in the church. I worked from the nurses registry there in the city. I paid them a fee and they would call to tell me the family that needed me for Private Duty nursing in a hospital room. After 3 years of that I worked in Dr. Al Mazats office as his nurse. I was very proud to accept this job. My white uniforms were laundered and ironed, waiting for me there.

After his family left Wichita to work as missionaries, the registry called me to a private home of a wealthy lady, Mrs. Walker. I would drive each day to Eastborough, the wealthiest section of Wichita, for private nursing duty. She asked me to stay on with her nearly two years. She gave us many lovely gifts and clothes.

At this time Mike was going to Friends University studying Education to become a teacher. He worked such long hours after school hanging paper in homes. He got contracts to paper a row of new homes occasionally, and would work most of the night. Then be sleepy in class the next day but still make good grades. We were both hard workers raising our three big kids at that time. Thanks for our parents help too.

We moved to California when Michael was 15 years old and in the Academy. Mike stayed in Kansas another 6 months to finish the University. The 3 kids and I drove one of dads cars for the move to California. Mom and dad drove their other car and a trailer of furniture. Mother didn't really want to leave her home in Kansas, but Carolyn lived out here too, so.....

Mike had to sell our home after graduation before he came out here to live in California. Had several trips out here to visit us and get us settled in a new duplex. The kids started in school and in January he was finally here to stay. After 2 years in Loma Linda we moved to a wonderful new home in Redlands on Palm Ave. It had a bedroom, drapes and carpeting for everyone of us. What a beautiful treat! Michael was ready for college and Steve a Junior in the Academy. Kathy was 14 years old. We loved that beautiful house and yard on the corner lot.

I had been working at Redlands Hospital on the maternity floor. I then asked to work for Dr. DeSalvo as his office nurse. I stayed three years until he became ill. He died at age 56. His 3 kids were about the same age and names as ours!! So then I started working at L.L.U.M.C. At the "old" hospital as unit secretary on the surgical floors. Writing off the orders for different areas to be done from the Doctors. And dealing only with the Doctors and head nurse. It was a fascinating job and very taxing. But after 3 years it was going easy like clockwork. After 5 years of that we moved into the huge new hospital we all now use in Loma Linda.

During the 20 years with the 2 hospitals I took a nursing course and worked at least 2 weeks in all areas. When doing the clinical part of it for experience. I am still a CA licensed nurse. L.V.N. and every 2 years I renew it by turning in 30 hours of classroom lectures to the state plus a fee of \$75. This is a big satisfaction.

There's many years of hard work to raise 3 children and help them through college. Now that the men are in Education and Kathy is making wonderful use of her B.S. in Executive Secretary study. Graduating from LaSierra College. We're proud of all of them.

Mike lost so much weight in Wichita and while working out here teaching plus an extra job working part time. He stayed thin several years. He drove into L.A. State University several nights a week to get his Masters degree. He taught special ed. Classes for several years, then sixth grade. Then he was a teacher/principal at Cram elementary Half a year. And then was asked to go to Lugonia for half a year. Then he asked to go into the main office to be business manager

He balanced a big budget for all the schools in Redlands for five ^{8 1/2} years. Then to Ontario As business superintendent for one year then Superintendent for 12 years. He managed 9 high schools and all the personnel. A really big job, a big thing. He had such a large responsibility he could hardly believe it. So many wonderful things happened for him, so many opportunities. Jobs to do, people to meet, organizations to belong to. Lifetime experiences that really were breathless and unbelievable. He knew how to work with difficult people and had his five board members as friends that trusted him. He took lots of responsibilities off of their shoulders. Built a new high school by making plans and many, many trips to Sacramento. There he contacted the right people to accomplish things. Noone ever comprehended all the work he has done, the various jobs and experience it took to get where he is now. His last year at Chino he earned \$130,000 dollars. He is a highly professional and accomplished man, and I am very proud of him.

His loving and devoted wife,
Eileen

1992